

2c. Content of Human interactions (H481/02)

The Human interactions (02) component is built around two main topics, Global Connections and Changing Spaces; Making Places. It investigates the actions, interactions and spatial patterns of people in places. Learners will build a picture of how the world around them is shaped by humans, starting from the local and moving out to regional, national and international scales.

Through examples and case studies learners will explore a variety of contrasting places, unpicking the flows and connections that have made them what they are and the way in which global systems and governance have local consequences. The concepts of inequality, interdependence, representation, identity and globalisation are particularly relevant to this component and qualitative research and fieldwork opportunities complement it well.

Topic 2.1 – Changing Spaces; Making Places

“Our lack of thinking about place and space risks turning challenges into crises.” – Royal Town Planning Institute, UK

People are at the heart of places, living their lives, forming attachments and making connections. Places are dynamic, multi-layered and the history and culture of a nation can be found in its buildings, public spaces and towns and cities. Our environment includes a wide variety of places, from rural to urban, small streets to megacities and diversity exists not only between but also within all of these places.

Places are connected to other places and there are few left untouched by the forces of globalisation. Changing Spaces; Making Places allows learners to look through a local lens to understand global issues.

Starting from the local place in which learners live and moving outwards to the regional, national and global scale in order to understand the interconnections and dynamics of place. Investigating how shifting flows of people, money and resources are shaping places, whilst economic changes are contributing to a landscape of haves and have nots.

Exploration of the relationships and connections between people, the economy, and society and how these contribute to creating places. Placemaking projects are explored, considering the meanings and representations created and attached to places. Placemaking projects can happen at a variety of levels from individual project, street level, cultural quarter or whole city level.

1. What's in a place?

Key Ideas	Content
1.a. Places are multi-faceted, shaped by shifting flows and connections which change over time.	• Case studies of two contrasting place profiles at a local scale, including: ◦ their demographic, socio-economic, cultural, political, built and natural characteristics that shape their place identity. ◦ their past and present connections that shape the place identity and embed them in regional, national, international and global scales ◦ how shifting flows of people (such as commuter, migration), resources (such as natural, technology), money and investment (such as EU funding, TNCs) and ideas (such as knowledge economy) have helped shape the demographic, socio-economic and cultural profile of these places over time.

2. How do we understand place?

Key Ideas	Content
2.a. People see, experience and understand place in different ways, this can also change over time.	• The complexities that exist when trying to define place, including the concept of space versus place. • How and why people perceive places in different ways based on their identity, including age, gender, sexuality, religion and role. • How level of emotional attachment to place can influence people's behaviour and activities in a place. • How the processes of globalisation and time-space compression can influence our sense of place.

2. How do we understand place?

Key Ideas	Content
2.b. Places are represented through a variety of contrasting formal and informal agencies.	• How informal representations of a place differ through contrasting media such as TV, film, music, art, photography, literature, graffiti and blogs. • Identify how formal and statistical representations of a place, such as census and geospatial data, contrasts with informal representations.

3. How does economic change influence patterns of social inequality in places?

Key Ideas	Content
3.a. The distribution of resources, wealth and opportunities are not evenly spread within and between places.	• The concept of social inequality and how this can be measured through indices such as housing, healthcare, education, employment and access to services. • How and why spatial patterns of social inequalities vary both within and between places.
3.b. Processes of economic change can create opportunities for some while creating and exacerbating social inequality for others.	• The influence of global connections and globalisation in driving structural economic change in places, such as de-industrialisation and the rise of the service industry. • How structural economic change impacts patterns of social opportunities and inequality for people and places. • How cyclical economic change (booms and recessions) has varied impacts on social opportunities and inequality. • The role of government in reducing, reinforcing and creating patterns of social inequality in places through spending or cuts in key services such as availability and accessibility of education, healthcare, infrastructure and community services.
3.c. Social inequality impacts people and places in different ways.	• Case studies of two contrasting places to illustrate: ◦ the types of evidence of social inequality that can be found there such as housing, environmental quality, crime rates, digital divide ◦ the range of factors that influence people's social inequality such as income, gender, age, health, personal mobility, ethnicity and education ◦ how social inequality impacts upon people's daily lives in different ways.

4. Who are the players that influence economic change in places?

Key Ideas	Content
4.a. Places are influenced by a range of players operating at different scales.	• The role of players in driving economic change, including at least one of local and national government, MNCs or international institutions. • Case study of one country or region that has been impacted by structural economic change, including: ◦ socio-economic, demographic, cultural and environmental characteristics of the place before the economic change ◦ the economic change/changes that took place and the role of players involved in driving the change ◦ socio-economic, demographic, cultural and environmental impacts on people and place.

5. How are places created through placemaking processes?

Key Ideas	Content
5.a. Place is produced in a variety of ways at different scales.	• The concept of placemaking and how governments and organisations attempt to present places to the wider world to attract inward investment and regeneration. • How architects and planners attempt to create meaningful and authentic places through design, such as places that encourage mixed community use or the 24 hour city. • How local community groups shape the place they live, such as residents associations, heritage associations and social media.
5.b. The placemaking process of rebranding constructs a different place meaning through reimagining and regeneration.	• Why places rebrand through reimagining and regeneration to construct a different place meaning. • How a range of strategies can be used to rebrand places, such as sport, art, heritage, retail, architecture and food. These can be used singularly or in conjunction to change a place meaning. • A range of players and their role in placemaking, including government/EU funding, corporate bodies, not for profit organisations and community groups. • How and why some groups of people contest efforts to rebrand a place.
5.c. Making a successful place requires planning and design.	• Case study of one place that has undergone rebranding, including: ◦ why the place needed to rebrand ◦ strategy/strategies involved in the rebranding of the place ◦ the role and influence of a range of players involved in the placemaking ◦ how the rebranding has altered people's perception of that place ◦ the relative success of the rebranding.

6. Topic-specific skills:

- appreciate how qualitative approaches actively create particular place representations
- analysing the impacts of different media on place meanings and perceptions
- the use of geospatial data to present place characteristics
- how quantitative data is used to present place characteristics.